GROW FASTER

PEOPLE | ORGANISATIONS | IMPACT

EXECUTIVE PREVIEW

The Coherent Enterprise

Why complexity is quietly breaking modern organisations

and how to move with coherence

ERLEND HOLLEBOSCH

Executive preview of the manuscript

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Five minutes, one question

This preview introduces *The Coherent Enterprise* by Erlend Hollebosch: a manuscript about why capable organisations become harder to move, and what leaders can do about it.

> **How do organisations continue moving coherently as complexity continues to expand?**
>
> THE QUESTION THE MANUSCRIPT EXPLORES

Read it in order, or start with the chapter that matches what you see in your own organisation.

Your route through the preview

You see slow progress
Activity is high, momentum is not
Page 5 · The Enterprise Paradox

You see overlapping change
Initiatives that collide instead of combine
Page 6 · Why Complexity Has Changed

You see coordination overload
Dependencies, longer decision paths
Page 7 · Why Enterprises Fragment

You want the answer
Coherence as a capability to build
Page 8 · Coherence as Strategic Capability

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A quieter pattern beneath success

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More activity, less movement

03 **Why Complexity Has Changed** 6
From temporary to structural

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The relationships, not the parts

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The next competitive advantage

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Scale, transformation, coherence

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Moving together as complexity grows

> “The defining challenge of modern enterprises may no longer be capability, but coherence.
>
> EXECUTIVE INTRODUCTION

CHAPTER 01 · EXECUTIVE INTRODUCTION

01

Most organisations are not failing

They continue investing in technology, transformation, governance, talent and growth. Many remain profitable, continue expanding and appear successful by conventional measures. Yet beneath that success, a quieter pattern is emerging.

More coordination

Decisions require more coordination.

More dependencies

Initiatives demand greater alignment; dependencies multiply.

Slower progress

Transformation efforts overlap; progress feels slower than expected.

Leaders increasingly describe organisations that are becoming harder to move. The organisation remains active, yet progress often feels slower than expected.

EXECUTIVE INSIGHT · THE CENTRAL QUESTION

What if these symptoms are not isolated problems, but signs of a broader structural condition? **What if the defining challenge of modern enterprises is no longer capability, but coherence?**

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Success by conventional measures can hide a loss of movement.
- Slower progress is a pattern, not a series of isolated problems.
- The manuscript asks how organisations keep moving coherently as complexity grows.

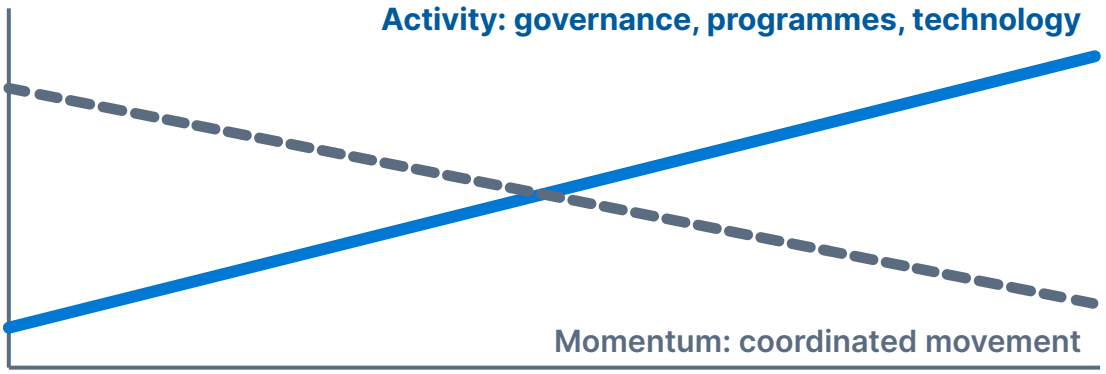
02

More of everything, less movement

A senior executive recently summarised a challenge heard across many enterprises:

> **We have more governance, more transformation, more technology... and somehow less movement.**
>
> A SENIOR EXECUTIVE

The organisation remained successful by traditional measures, with growing revenue, active transformation programmes and increasing technology investments. Yet internally, progress slowed as coordination, dependencies and alignment became increasingly difficult to manage.



Complexity grows → (conceptual, not measured data)

As complexity expands, organisations spend more energy maintaining alignment than creating momentum. **Activity remains high, but momentum declines.**

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✔ Organisations were long constrained by capability; many are now constrained by coherence.
- ✔ The leadership challenge: sustain coherent movement as complexity grows.

03

Complexity is now structural

For decades, organisations treated complexity as a problem that could be reduced through structures, processes and operating models. Today, complexity has become structural rather than temporary.

FRAMEWORK · OVERLAPPING SYSTEMS OF CHANGE

SYSTEM 1
Digital transformation

SYSTEM 2
AI adoption

SYSTEM 3
Regulation

SYSTEM 4
Ecosystem dependencies

The challenge no longer comes from individual initiatives, but from the growing interactions between them.

As complexity increases, coordination demands grow and alignment becomes harder to sustain. The challenge is therefore no longer simply managing complexity. **It is preserving coherence and coordinated movement within it.**

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✔ Complexity can no longer be designed away; it is permanent.
- ✔ The risk sits in the interactions between initiatives, not in any one of them.
- ✔ The task shifts from managing complexity to moving coherently within it.

04

Fragmentation lives between the parts

Organisations rarely fragment because individual teams fail. They fragment because growing complexity makes the connections between teams, systems and stakeholders harder to manage.

ILLUSTRATION · CONNECTIONS GROW FASTER THAN PARTS

5 TEAMS	10 TEAMS	20 TEAMS
10 possible connections	**45** possible connections	**190** possible connections

Pairs between n parts: n × (n − 1) ÷ 2. Doubling the parts roughly quadruples the relationships to manage.

As interactions increase, dependencies multiply, decision paths lengthen and coordination consumes more organisational energy. The challenge shifts from managing individual components to **managing the relationships between them.**

Fragmentation emerges when these relationships become too numerous or too dependent on continuous synchronisation.

> **Organisations rarely struggle from a lack of capability. They struggle when capability can no longer move coherently together.**
>
> WHY ENTERPRISES FRAGMENT

05

The next advantage may be coherence itself

For decades, organisations competed through scale, efficiency, speed and transformation. The complexity era may reward something different: **coherence**.

COHERENCE IS NOT

- **Consensus**
  Everyone agreeing
- **Simplicity**
  Fewer moving parts
- **Centralised control**
  Decisions pulled to the top

COHERENCE IS

- **Coordinated movement**
  Sustained despite increasing complexity
- **Preserving alignment**
  The parts keep pulling in one direction
- **Continuity and adaptability**
  Changing without losing the whole

As complexity continues to grow, the organisations that succeed may not be those that transform the most or move the fastest, but those that remain coherent while transforming continuously.

FOR THE EXECUTIVE TEAM

Treat coherence as an organisational ability to build and measure, **not as a state of agreement to reach once.**

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✔ Coherence is the ability to move together, not the absence of difference.
- ✔ It preserves alignment, continuity and adaptability at the same time.
- ✔ Winners may be the most coherent, not the fastest or most transformed.

06

Every era has its defining challenge

1 **Scale**
The defining challenge of the twentieth century — **20th century**

2 **Transformation**
The defining challenge of the early twenty-first century — **Early 21st**

3 **Coherence**
The defining challenge of the complexity era — **Now**

As complexity, interdependence and the pace of change continue to increase, many organisational challenges may share a common cause: **a growing gap between complexity and coherence.**

SYMPTOMS THAT MAY SHARE ONE CAUSE

1. Decision bottlenecks
2. Governance congestion
3. Transformation fatigue
4. Fragmented execution

The manuscript argues that the key leadership question is no longer how organisations become more capable, but how they remain coherent as complexity expands.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✔ Scale, then transformation, now coherence.
- ✔ Familiar symptoms may share one cause: the complexity–coherence gap.
- ✔ The organisations that thrive preserve coordinated movement while adapting.

CHAPTER 07 · CLOSING REFLECTION

07

Complexity is now a permanent condition

Modern organisations are entering an era where complexity is no longer an occasional challenge, but a permanent condition. The question is not whether complexity will grow, but whether organisations can continue moving coherently as it does.

For more than a century, management focused on building capability. The next challenge may be preserving coherence across that capability. Organisations rarely struggle because complexity exists, but because it grows faster than their ability to coordinate, align and move together.

> **The enterprises that thrive may not be those that change the fastest, but those that remain coherent as complexity continues to expand.**
>
> CLOSING REFLECTION

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Complexity will keep growing; that is no longer the question.
- The risk is complexity outpacing the ability to coordinate and align.
- Coherence across capability is the next management discipline.

NEXT STEPS

Continue with the full manuscript

The full manuscript explores how strategy, governance, decisions, operations, technology and learning reinforce one another as an organisation changes.

IN THE FULL MANUSCRIPT

1. **Understand** why capable organisations become harder to move as complexity grows.
2. **Diagnose** where coherence erodes with the Coherence Diagnostic Model.
3. **Redesign** governance, decisions and flow with the Coherent Transformation Playbook.

About the author

Erlend Hollebosch works on enterprise coherence and AI transformation, with a background in Agile, Lean and process optimisation.

The full manuscript

281 pages, shared personally on request · grow-faster.be

Download the preview

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Coherence decides what AI amplifies.

The Coherent Enterprise — why complexity is quietly breaking modern organisations and how to move with coherence.

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